

MIG-18

Migrant Interview: Inclusion and Xenophobia

Interviewee Profile

Interview code: MIG-18

Age: 38

Gender: Male

Country of origin: India

Host country: United Kingdom

Years in host country: 8

Occupation: Small Business Owner

Interview

Q1. Can you tell me about your journey and what brought you to your host country?

A: I came to the United Kingdom eight years ago to join family members who were already established here and to start a business, following a long and well-worn tradition of Indian entrepreneurship in Britain that stretches back generations. The UK's substantial and established Indian community, along with the genuine business opportunities available, drew me here rather than elsewhere. I wanted to build something of my own, an enterprise that I could grow and be proud of, and to provide a good and secure life for my family in a country that has deep historical ties to India and where people like me had put down roots long before I arrived. Having family already here made the transition considerably smoother than it would otherwise have been, and I am grateful for that.

Q2. What does 'inclusion' mean to you personally?

A: Inclusion means that my business serves the whole community, not just members of my own ethnic group, and that I am seen and treated as a British entrepreneur rather than merely as an ethnic shopkeeper confined to a narrow niche. It shows itself when my children are treated as fully and unquestionably British, with the same belonging as anyone else, and when I am able to participate in civic and community life as a full member. Belonging, for me, is the feeling that this is genuinely and permanently my home, a place where my contributions are recognised and valued across all communities and where my family's place is secure and unquestioned, rather than a place where we are always somehow marked as being from elsewhere.

Q3. Have you experienced xenophobia or discrimination? Can you describe it?

A: I have faced xenophobia periodically over the years, including outright racist comments and the underlying assumption, expressed in various ways, that I do not really belong here despite my citizenship and my years of contribution. During certain politically charged moments, such as the period around the Brexit debate and referendum, the hostility toward immigrants became noticeably more open and emboldened, as though people felt newly licensed to express feelings they had previously kept to themselves. As a visible minority running a business open to the public, I have had to deal with prejudiced and occasionally abusive customers, and with the persistent, wounding 'go back

home' sentiment that surfaces from time to time, reminding me that some will always see me as a foreigner.

Q4. What have been the biggest challenges in adapting to your new country?

A: The challenges included navigating British business regulations, the paperwork and the rules and the compliance, along with the intense competition and the significant economic pressures that bear down on small retailers in particular, who operate on thin margins in a difficult market. Building a loyal customer base and establishing myself and my business took hard work, long hours, and considerable persistence over several years. While the established Indian community provided valuable help, advice, and connections, integrating fully into the broader British society beyond that community, and overcoming the occasional prejudice I encountered, required real patience and sustained effort, and it did not happen overnight or without setbacks along the way.

Q5. How would you describe your experience in the workplace or professional environment?

A: My business brings me into daily contact with the whole surrounding community, and most of my customers are friendly, loyal, and decent regardless of their background, which has been genuinely heartening over the years. I employ a diverse staff, and we work together well and harmoniously toward the shared goal of running a good business. The occasional hostile or prejudiced customer is very much the exception and is far outweighed by the many warm and positive relationships I have built with regulars and neighbours alike. My shop has become, in a small way, a hub that brings different kinds of people together every day, and I take real pride in that role within the community.

Q6. How do you balance maintaining your cultural identity with integrating into the host society?

A: I maintain my Indian identity through our family traditions, through festivals like Diwali which we celebrate fully and joyfully, through our cuisine, and through my faith, all of which I actively pass on to my children so that they know and value where they come from. At the same time, I have genuinely embraced British life and British values, and I feel authentically at home here after all these years. I identify comfortably as British Indian, rooted securely in both parts of that identity without any sense of contradiction, and I see myself as contributing to the rich multicultural fabric that defines modern Britain, a fabric to which Indians have contributed for a very long time.

Q7. How do you feel the media portrays migrants from your background?

A: British media has considerably more Indian representation than many other places, given the size and long history of the Indian community here, which is genuinely positive, but stereotypes of Indians as shopkeepers, taxi drivers, or IT workers still stubbornly persist and limit how we are imagined. More diverse and complex portrayals, showing the full range of British Indian lives and achievements, would certainly help to broaden perceptions. On the whole, though, the increasing visibility of successful British Indians across many different fields, in politics, business, medicine, the arts, has improved how we are perceived over time, even if limiting and reductive stereotypes still linger in certain quarters and certain contexts.

Q8. Have integration programs or community support been helpful in your experience?

A: By the time I arrived here, the well-established Indian community itself provided most of the support and guidance I needed, considerably more than any government programme did, through

informal networks of advice, connection, and practical help from those who had walked the same path before me. This kind of community network is genuinely invaluable for newcomers and smooths the way enormously. The UK's general, official integration support is fairly limited in my experience, but for Indians specifically, the strong and long-established existing community fills many of the gaps, helping newcomers to settle, to find their footing, and to build their lives relatively smoothly compared to those who arrive without such a network to rely upon.

Q9. How has the next generation (or younger migrants) adapted compared to you?

A: My children are thoroughly British, speaking with local accents and being fully and naturally part of British society, which makes me proud, even as they navigate the particular experience of having a dual identity. They celebrate and understand their Indian heritage while being unmistakably and confidently British at the same time, holding both with ease. They do occasionally face racism, which pains me, but they are confident, resilient, and successful, and they do not let it define them or hold them back. This generation, to my mind, embodies the successful integration of Indians into British life, at home in the country of their birth while proud of the heritage of their family, and I could not ask for more than that.

Q10. In your opinion, what would help reduce xenophobia in society?

A: To reduce xenophobia, celebrating the long history and the substantial contributions of Indians and of other immigrant communities to Britain is important, so that people understand we are not recent or unwelcome arrivals but long-standing contributors to the nation's life. Media diversity certainly helps to broaden perceptions and challenge stereotypes. And personal relationships are key, as they always are; my own business demonstrates daily that when people interact positively across cultures in the ordinary course of life, buying and selling, chatting, getting to know one another, prejudice diminishes and gives way to familiarity. That everyday contact between communities builds the mutual respect and understanding that ultimately counters and dissolves hostility far more effectively than anything else.

Q11. What are your hopes and dreams for the future?

A: I hope to continue expanding my business and, in time, to pass on a thriving and successful enterprise to my children, should they wish to take it on and build upon what I have created. I want to become more involved in local community leadership, giving back to the place that has become my home and helping to strengthen the ties between its different communities. And looking further ahead, I dream of my family being fully and permanently accepted as British while still cherishing and maintaining our Indian roots, contributing to the ongoing prosperity, vitality, and diversity of our community and our adopted country for generations to come.

Q12. What advice would you give to new migrants arriving in your host country?

A: My advice to newcomers is to make full use of community networks, which are absolutely invaluable for support, guidance, and connection, especially in the early and uncertain days when you know little and need much. Work hard and consistently to build your reputation and your business, because both are earned over time through effort and integrity. Make a genuine effort to engage with the broader community beyond your own ethnic group, however comfortable that group may be, because full belonging requires reaching outward. Instill real pride in both cultures in your children, so they carry both forward. And be resilient in the face of prejudice, letting your contributions and your

character define how you are ultimately seen.